

Social Context, Part 1 – OpenRefine Issues Analysis

This document identifies three open issues from the OpenRefine GitHub issue tracker that I would personally like to work on. I selected these issues based on the following criteria: They are labeled as **Good First Issue**, making them suitable for contributors who are still learning the codebase. They involve frontend usability or feature improvements, which match my interests in software engineering and user experience. They appear manageable in scope while still having meaningful impact on the project and community. These issues are valuable because they improve usability, accessibility, and user interaction within OpenRefine. Working on these tasks would also help me better understand the architecture of a large open-source Java and JavaScript project.

Issue #6697 – Recon Suggest Widget: Enable Middle-Click to Open URL in New Tab

Issue Link: <https://github.com/OpenRefine/OpenRefine/issues/6697>

This issue focuses on improving the usability of the reconciliation suggestion widget by allowing users to middle-click links and open them in a new browser tab without automatically selecting the entity. I chose this issue because it directly improves the user experience and seems approachable for someone learning the frontend structure of OpenRefine.

I am interested in this issue because I enjoy working on UI behavior and usability improvements. Small interaction changes like this can significantly improve workflow efficiency for users working with large datasets.

Issue #6303 – Refresh Button in Wikibase Preview Tab

Issue Link: <https://github.com/OpenRefine/OpenRefine/issues/6303>

This issue requests adding a refresh button to the Wikibase preview tab. The feature would allow users to refresh previews more conveniently without manually restarting or repeating actions. I selected this issue because it combines frontend interaction with feature enhancement in an important OpenRefine extension.

This issue matches my interests because I want to gain more experience understanding how UI components communicate with backend data updates in larger software systems.

Issue #3012 – Python Expression Preview Doesn't Always Report Errors

Issue Link: <https://github.com/OpenRefine/OpenRefine/issues/3012>

This issue concerns error handling for Python expressions in OpenRefine. Currently, some invalid expressions fail silently or do not provide clear error feedback to the user. I selected this issue because improving debugging and error reporting is very important in software engineering.

I am motivated to work on this issue because it would help me understand how OpenRefine processes expressions internally and how the system handles exceptions and user feedback.

Conclusion:

The three selected issues are realistic entry points into the OpenRefine open-source community. They are well-scoped, and aligned with my interests in software engineering, frontend usability, and software quality. Working on these issues would help me improve my technical skills while contributing meaningful improvements to an actively maintained open-source project.